

CRIME

Pierce County Sheriff's Office to deactivate its license-plate reader cameras

By **Puneet Bsanti**

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Governor Bob Ferguson signed SB 6002 to regulate license plate readers in Washington. The law limits data retention and bans cameras near sensitive locations. By TVW

The Sheriff's Office in Pierce County will deactivate its Automated License Plate Reader system following a new law that regulates the use of the technology by

local and state agencies.

The Driver Privacy Act, or Senate Bill 6002, establishes new regulations for the use of ALPR systems, including limiting the technology's data collection and retention for privacy protections of drivers. Gov. Bob Ferguson signed the [bill into law Monday after it was passed in the Legislature](#).

The Sheriff's Office said in a news release the continued use of the ALPR system, or Flock cameras, would place deputies at risk of unintentionally violating the new state law.

"Among its provisions, the law prohibits the use of license plate readers in proximity to community locations, including hospitals, schools, and other protected areas. Violations of these restrictions carry significant legal consequences, including classification as a Gross Misdemeanor for individual officers," according to the release.

The release said there is no available technology or capability that allows the Sheriff's Office to ensure the cameras can reliably differentiate between restricted and permitted locations in real time.

Sheriff Keith Swank said the decision to deactivate the cameras was not made lightly, according to the release.

"ALPR technology has been instrumental in locating missing persons, including Silver Alert cases, identifying stolen vehicles, and apprehending dangerous offenders. Without it, our ability to respond quickly and effectively is diminished," the release said.

The law also makes it unlawful for any agency to use the reader for immigration investigations or enforcement.

"The Pierce County Sheriff's Office also acknowledges that broader concerns surrounding privacy and the potential use of such technologies in connection

with federal immigration enforcement, including issues related to Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE), have contributed to the passage of this legislation. While the intent of the law is to address those concerns, its practical impact at the local level is the removal of a critical investigative resource,” according to the Sheriff’s Office news release.

The release ended with the office saying it would continue to explore lawful and effective alternatives to support their mission.

Swank addressed the Sheriff’s Office’s decision [in an X post Tuesday morning](#).

“These cameras were not used to track people. We used them to get hits on wanted vehicles. The camera runs plates, and if it is a wanted vehicle, the deputy is notified. If it is not a wanted vehicle, the information is not even gathered,” Swank wrote.

Swank wrote the law would hinder the office, citing searching for homicide suspects or finding missing dementia patients.

“I am not saying this because, ‘I’m mad, and I’m taking my toys home.’ I am not mad about it. I am just letting you know our solve rate and prosecution rate will decrease,” he wrote.

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